at the time of army's revolt. Now he was forty-seven years old, head of his clan, veteran and survivor of a quarter century of civil war. Unlike his predecessors, Chung-heon had a long-term plan. He did not intend to rule by controlling the unruly Goryeo army; the series of graves outside the capital city's walls had convinced him of the pointlessness of such a strategy.

Nor did he aspire to claim the crown.

To put his own sons on the Goryeo throne would be to shatter the mystique of the long-lasting Goryeo dynasty; such a move might energize a whole new civilian resistance to the military dictatorship. A year after seizing power, he suggested to the now-elderly king Myeongjong that he abdicate because of his failing health. Myeongjong, probably relieved to be given a nonfatal way off the throne, quickly agreed. In his place, Chung-heon organized the coronation of Myeongjong's younger brother Sinjong, who was even more malleable: "Sinjong was put upon the throne by Choe Chung-heon," says the *Goryeosa*, "and all matters of life and death, decisions to accept or to reject, were in Choe's hands. Sinjong stood above his subjects holding only empty authority. Alas, he was nothing but a puppet."[14]

Just after Sinjong's coronation, Chung-heon's younger brother and co-ruler, Choe Chung-su, decided to push for the marriage of his own daughter to Sinjong's son, now crown prince. The older brother disagreed sharply with this strategy. "Now, brother," he is said to have objected, "although our power can shake the country, our lineage was originally humble. If we have your daughter marry the crown prince, will we not be criticized?" When Choe Chung-su ignored his counsel and pushed ahead with the betrothal, the two brothers quarreled so violently that their supporters divided and began to fight in the streets. In the struggle, Chung-su was killed.[15]

Now Choe Chung-heon was in sole control of the throne, and his ultimate plan grew clear. Rather than becoming head of an army administration or part of the royal family, he intended to rule as a private citizen. His own personal guards, supplemented by troops who owed loyalty directly to him, became a separate and independent army within the capital, answering only to Choe Chung-heon. At first, they simply guarded his house. As time went on, they were augmented by mercenaries, deserters from the regular army, and new allies, until Choe Chung-heon controlled thirty-six armed units of well-trained fighters. "The bravest soldiers were all Choe Chung-heon's," says the *Goryeosa*, "[and] those in the government army were all thin and weak and useless."[16]

Over the next decades, Choe Chung-heon would slowly transfer more and more of the government's powers—including tax collection and the prosecution of lawbreakers—over to his own private control. Meanwhile, he